18.6.5 Delegation as constrained authority

This approach reinforces a key principle: agents cannot delegate authority they do not have, nor can they expand authority through delegation.

Delegation does not create new permissions. It narrows existing permissions to a specific, task-bound scope. Policies remain the ultimate authority, and delegation data defines the boundaries within which those policies apply.

In this model, delegation is a controlled and auditable mechanism for distributing work across agents. Each action taken by a subagent is evaluated in context, ensuring that responsibility can be shared without sacrificing control.

18.6.6 Extending the policy-aware architecture

Delegation builds directly on the policy-aware architecture introduced earlier in this chapter.

- In section 18.3, authorization was integrated into the agent's execution loop.
- In section 18.4, policy constraints were used to guide planning.

Here, delegation extends the model by allowing authority to be distributed across agents while preserving enforcement. The same policy engine evaluates all decisions. The only difference is the information provided as input.

At ACME, this approach enabled agents to collaborate on complex tasks without establishing implicit trust relationships. Subagents could operate independently, but every action they took remained bounded by explicit, policy-enforced constraints.

As one of the engineers summarized during an architecture review: agents can help each other, but they cannot grant powers they do not already have. Delegation is therefore a natural extension of policy-based authorization. It enables flexible cooperation while maintaining strict control over how authority is used.